

GA.4 Where to File Directory

The offices a Georgia owner-builder deals with, how to find each one for your parcel, and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. In Georgia the state minimum codes bind statewide, but permits and inspections are a local option — each county or city decides its own forms, fees, and enforcement, and some enforce nothing at all. Confirm every item with the office that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

WHO ISSUES YOUR PERMIT DEPENDS ON WHERE YOUR LOT IS

The codes are statewide; the counter is not. Permitting is a power granted to "*the governing body of any municipality or county adopting any state minimum standard code*" (§ 8-2-26(a)). Inside city limits the city usually issues (some contract back to the county); in the unincorporated county, the county issues **where a building department exists at all** — and where none does, there is no permit to pull, though the codes still bind your work (§ 8-2-25(a); see GA.2 and GA.3).

Settle this first — it decides everything else

Before you gather a single document, confirm three things: whether your parcel is **inside a municipality, which government** (if any) issues building permits for it, and **who runs the inspections**. Call the county with your parcel ID and ask directly — in Georgia this one call can change the entire path.

HOW TO FIND EACH OFFICE

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Building / permitting department (permits, plan review, inspections)	Search "[your county] GA building permit" and stay on the government's own domain. Metro departments run online portals — ask which one and register before you file.
Planning / zoning (setbacks, use, zoning verification)	Often a separate department, sometimes the same counter. Ask the permit office who confirms zoning and setbacks for your parcel.

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
County health department — environmental health (septic, wells)	Search "[your county] GA environmental health septic." Every county has one — this track exists even where no building department does.
GDOT District Area Office (driveway onto a state route)	Residential driveway applications go to the Area Office for your county — via dot.ga.gov. First confirm the road is actually a state route.
Erosion & sedimentation / land disturbance	Your certified Local Issuing Authority — usually the county or city; the EPD district office where none exists. Ask the permit office which applies.
Clerk of superior court (Notice of Commencement)	Files in the project's county within 15 days of commencing work (§ 44-14-361.5(b)). Ask whether your clerk publishes a fill-in form — contents list in GA.2 and GA.5.

Local-option enforcement: O.C.G.A. § 8-2-26(a); codes statewide regardless: § 8-2-25(a); Notice of Commencement venue: § 44-14-361.5(b). Verified August 2026.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each entry by phone rather than copying it from a search result, and write the date and the name of the person you spoke to — in a county office, a name is worth more than a number.

BUILDING / PERMITTING DEPARTMENT — issues the permit; schedules inspections — or confirms none exists

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PLANNING / ZONING — setbacks, zoning verification, address assignment

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

COUNTY HEALTH — ENVIRONMENTAL HEALTH — septic permit and final; wells

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

GDOT DISTRICT AREA OFFICE — driveway access onto a state route

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

LOCAL ISSUING AUTHORITY — E&S — land disturbance, if not exempt

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

CLERK OF SUPERIOR COURT — Notice of Commencement filing

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

UTILITIES — POWER / WATER / SEWER — construction power, permanent service, taps — or N/A if well/septic

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing; phone numbers are left for you to confirm. (One more: the Georgia Environmental Finance Authority, gefa.georgia.gov, is the state energy office — programs, not code. Code questions go to DCA.)

State agencies and what each is actually for (domains checked live, August 2026)

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Dept. of Community Affairs (DCA) Construction Codes & Industrialized Buildings	Publishes the state minimum codes and the Georgia Amendments. Code questions: codes@dca.ga.gov .	dca.georgia.gov
State Licensing Board for Residential and Commercial General Contractors (Secretary of State)	Licensing and owner-exemption questions; verify every contractor you hire. Older handouts say "Residential and General Contractors" — SB 503 (2024) renamed it; same board.	sos.ga.gov
Trade division boards (Secretary of State, O.C.G.A. ch. 43-14)	Electrical, plumbing, conditioned air, low-voltage, and utility licenses — verify every trade sub. The boards license people; they do not inspect houses.	sos.ga.gov

State agencies and what each is actually for (domains checked live, August 2026)

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Dept. of Public Health Environmental Health — On-Site Sewage	The state septic rules your county health department administers, and links to each county office.	dph.georgia.gov
Environmental Protection Division (EPD) Watershed Protection Branch	E&S oversight, NPDES construction stormwater (GAR100001 family, NOI forms), floodplain coordination, water well standards. E&S plan standards live with the Soil & Water Conservation Commission (gaswcc.georgia.gov).	epd.georgia.gov
Georgia DOT — District Area Offices	Driveway and encroachment permits on state routes, via the Area Office for your county.	dot.ga.gov

HIGH-VOLUME JURISDICTIONS

Domains verified live in August 2026 — treat the domain as the reliable key and search it for "building permit."

Metro Atlanta and Savannah permitting offices

Jurisdiction	Department (* = confirm name when you call)	Domain
Gwinnett County	Dept. of Planning & Development — Building Services	gwinnettcountry.com
Fulton County (unincorp.)	Public Works — Planning, Zoning & Permitting	fultoncountyga.gov
Cobb County	Community Development Agency — Building & Development	cobbcounty.gov
Cherokee County	Development Services Center	cherokeega.com
Forsyth County	Planning & Community Development *	forsythco.com
Paulding County	Community Development *	paulding.gov
Henry County	Building & Development Services *	henrycountyga.gov
Hall County	Building Inspections / Development Services *	hallcounty.org
City of Atlanta	Dept. of City Planning — Office of Buildings *	atlantaga.gov
Chatham County (unincorp.)	Building Safety & Regulatory Services *	chathamcountyga.gov
City of Savannah	Development Services *	savannahga.gov

Sources (verified August 2026): local-option permitting — O.C.G.A. § 8-2-26(a); statewide codes — § 8-2-25(a); Notice of Commencement venue — § 44-14-361.5(b). All domains checked live against the agencies' own sites; names marked * are customary, not verified titles.